Hello everyone! Today, I want to show you the differences between northern and southern dialects and a special case.

In China, there are many dialects, such as these(play audio). They all mean "Have you eaten?" And first of all, I want you to guess whether a dialect spoken in southwestern China, like this one, is classified as part of the northern or southern dialect group.

Actually, it belongs to the northern dialect group. Surprised, right? Well, I was also surprised when I first learned this. But I immediately noticed that the biggest difference between the northern and southern dialects is how easily we can understand them. To explain this more clearly, I will show you how to distinguish between northern and southern dialects and discuss why they're different. Then I will explain why the southwestern dialect belongs to the northern dialect group.

From what I showed just now, we can notice an obvious fact: We can understand the northern one easily in most situations even when we hear it for the first time. But we can't understand the southern one if we don't know anything about it. So, if we want to guess whether a dialect is northern or southern, we can consider whether we can understand the speaker easily. If we can, it may be a northern dialect. If not, it may be a southern dialect.

Then you may be curious about why there is such a difference. In my opinion, the most important factor is the difference in geography.

In the northern areas, people mainly lived on the plains, so it was easy to go to other cities. They also traveled between cities to trade or fight wars. Thus, they needed a common language to make communication easier. As a result, although people spoke different dialects, they could usually understand one another.

But in the southern areas, there were many hills and mountains which made communication between communities difficult. For the ancients, it was hard to go to other cities because transportation was limited, so they just remained in their local areas and communicated with only a small number of people. As a result, the people living in the same area spoke the same dialect but the dialects in different areas were different. Therefore, a person living in one village might not understand someone from a nearby village.

Then, let's think about the southwestern dialect. I'm from Guizhou, a southwestern province, and now I'll show you some examples. In the first one, we say... Then in the second one, we say... You see? It's easy to understand what I mean! This gives us a clue that the southwestern dialect belongs to the northern dialect group.

Then there comes a question: Why is a dialect spoken in southern China actually classified as a northern dialect? In my view, one major reason is migration. During the Ming and Qing periods, many migrants moved from northern China to southwestern China. They brought new farming techniques and tools which helped them adapt to the local environment and develop agriculture quickly. As their communities grew, they became influential in local government, trade and daily life. Then, local people and migrants gradually began to use a shared language, which later developed into the southwestern dialect.

It's interesting, isn't it? We can guess where a person comes from by the dialect he or she speaks. The way we speak in daily life reflects the history and features of our country. The next time you speak your own dialect, you may realize that it shows where you are from. It represents your root and connects you with your ancestors.